

JOHN AMPONG

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EDUCATIONAL BACKGROUND

University of South Carolina Ph.D. in Business Administration, Concentration in Finance	<i>2022–Present</i>
Xiamen University Master of Applied Economics in Financial Engineering	<i>2018–2020</i>
University of Cape Coast Bachelor of Management Studies (Hons.)	<i>2013–2017</i>

WORKING PAPERS

Can a Shareholder Focus Create Value for all Stakeholders? (with Matthew Souther)

- **Media Coverage:** *The Columbia Law School Blue Sky Blog* (June 10, 2025)
- **Conferences and Seminars:** Georgia State – *Management Science* AI & FinTech Conference (2025), Financial Management Association (2025), Southern Finance Association (2025), RCF-ECGI Corporate Finance and Governance Conference (2026 scheduled)
- **Awards:** *Best Paper Award* (Darla Moore School Business)

We develop a novel machine-learning technique analyzing earnings call transcripts to measure whether a manager's focus is on shareholders or external stakeholders. We find that managers focusing on shareholders generate significantly higher stock returns in subsequent periods. However, these higher returns do not come to the detriment of other stakeholders; we find that shareholder-focused firms experience far fewer adverse environmental and social incidents, and those that do occur are less severe. Using natural disasters as an instrument for managerial focus and exploiting exogenous shifts in firm orientation induced by CEO transitions, we find that a shareholder focus causally reduces adverse E&S outcomes across all horizons examined. We conclude that a shareholder-focused strategy creates maximum value for both shareholders and stakeholders.

Selective Attention: Do Mutual Fund Incentives Affect their Voting? (with Matthew Souther)

- **Conferences and Seminars:** Financial Management Association (2025), Southern Finance Association (2025), Global Finance Conference(2025)
- **Awards:** *First Year Paper Award*

In a sample of ballot items for which proxy advisor recommendations oppose management, we find that the likelihood of a mutual fund actively voting (deviating from proxy advisor recommendations) is significantly higher when the fund has larger monetary incentives tied to the portfolio holding. To address endogenous portfolio selection issues, we find the same result in a sample of passive index funds for which portfolio allocations are exogenous. Firms that are more commonly held by less incentivized funds have lower CEO delta and lower CEO turnover-performance sensitivity.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Changing the Subject: How Managerial Attention Reallocation Obscures Bad News

- **Conferences and Seminars:** AI in Finance Conference (2026 scheduled), Brownbag Seminar, University of South Carolina (2026)

I propose a measure of managerial attention reallocation from a manager's own historical baseline, constructed using BERTopic applied to earnings call transcripts from 2007 to 2023. I find that unusual attention reallocation predicts negative abnormal returns, elevated crash risk over horizons up to two years, persistently lower long-run returns, greater analyst forecast dispersion, declining forecast boldness, and elevated options market jump risk. It further predicts a significant rise in bad-news mandatory disclosures and adverse incidents in subsequent months. Markets and analysts consistently fail to extract this signal at the time of the call, suggesting that strategic redirection of managerial attention obscures deteriorating fundamentals in plain sight.

Tax Salience: Evidence from Corporate Call Transcripts (with Jason DeBacker)

We study how salient tax reforms are to U.S. corporations and whether the salience to taxation, as expressed through language used in corporate earnings calls, is related to the sensitivity of corporate valuation to tax changes. We also explore the relationship between salience and measuring of corporate tax planning/aggressiveness such as cash ETRs and the size of uncertain tax positions.

Who Do You Trust?: Evidence from Mutual Fund Managers Allocation Decision (with Omrane Guedhami and Sadok El Ghoul)

Preliminary results documented

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Empirical Corporate Finance, Corporate Governance, Shareholder Voting, ESG, Machine Learning in Finance

RESEARCH AND TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant

Prof. Matthew Souther, University of South Carolina	2023–Present
Prof. Gregory R. Niehaus, University of South Carolina	2022
Prof. Chen Haiqiang, Xiamen University	2019

Instructor/Teaching Assistant

Instructor of Record, Corporate Finance, University of South Carolina	Fall 2025
Investment Analysis and Portfolio Management, University of South Carolina	2023, 2024
Financial Statement Analysis, University of South Carolina	2022
Financial Economics, Xiamen University	2019
Quantitative Methods in Finance, University of Cape Coast	2017
Financial Management, University of Cape Coast	2017

CORPORATE EXPERIENCE

Internship, National Investment Bank, Kumasi, Ghana	2016
Internship, CSIR-Building and Road Research Institute, Kumasi, Ghana	2015

SCHOLARSHIPS AND AWARDS

Doctoral Fellows Award for Outstanding Academic & Research Performance	2026, 2025
University of South Carolina, Graduate School Travel Grant	2025
Best Second Year Paper Award, University of South Carolina	2024
First Year Paper Award, University of South Carolina	2023
Business Administration Scholarship, University of South Carolina	2022, 2023, 2024
Excellent International Student Award, Xiamen University	2020
Chinese Government Scholarship, Xiamen University	2018
Scholarship for First Class Students, ICA, Ghana	2017
Dean's Awards for High Academic Performance, University of Cape Coast	2015, 2016, 2017

SERVICE

Reviewer, Eastern Finance Association (EFA)	2025
Reviewer, Southern Finance Association (SFA)	2025
Discussant, FMA, SFA	2025
Brown Bag Coordinator, Darla Moore, Finance Department	2024–Present
Ph.D. students recruitment assistant, Darla Moore, Finance Department	2024
Student Assistant, WISE-SOE international students, Xiamen University	2019
Co-Organizer and Speaker, WISE-SOE International Students Orientation	2019
Head of the Finance Committee, UCC Association of Business Students	2016

MAJOR CONFERENCES AND SEMINARS ATTENDED

AI in Finance Conference	(scheduled)
RCF-ECGI Corporate Finance and Governance Conference	(scheduled)
Georgia State – <i>Management Science</i> AI & FinTech Conference	2025
Financial Management Association(FMA) Vancouver, Canada	2025
Southern Finance Association(SFA) Conference Florida, USA	2025
SFS Cavalcade North America, New Jersey, USA	2025
32nd Annual Global Finance Conference, Boston Massachusetts, USA	2025
SFS Cavalcade North America, Atlanta-Georgia, USA	2024
Frontiers in International Finance Conference, South Carolina	2024
FMA Conference, Atlanta-Georgia, USA	2022
Fixed Income and Financial Institution Conference, South Carolina	2022–2024
Asian Meeting of the Econometric Society, Xiamen University, China	2019
Bank of America Merrill Lynch Summer Program, University of Ghana	2017

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Machine Learning, Python, SAS, Stata, R, SLURM, L^AT_EX

INTERESTS AND HOBBIES

Teaching, soccer, country music

REFERENCES

Professor Matthew Souther

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